

Who Speaks for the People?

Electoral Reforms, Parliamentary Speech, and Legislative Behaviour in Belgium, 1880–1912

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Abstract

Does extending the franchise change what a parliament attends to, and if so, does it work by changing the behaviour of the politicians already in office or by changing who holds office? We study this question in Belgium, which introduced plural male suffrage in 1894 and proportional representation in 1900, using a new dataset that links the plenary interventions of both chambers of parliament between 1880 and 1912 to the speaker's party and constituency, and to the bills that members introduced. The share of each intervention devoted to labour and social policy is measured by a transformer classifier trained for this corpus and validated against blind human coding. Because its eligibility census prevented working-class candidates from entering the Senate, the difference between the two chambers identifies the Chamber's differential response to electoral exposure, net of shocks common to both chambers, such as the strikes and unrest that produced the reforms. After enfranchisement, the Chamber's attention to the social question rose by 4.5 percentage points relative to the Senate's, on a base of 7.9, everywhere in the country and mainly among sitting deputies. Proportional representation produced no aggregate shift but a large effect in the coalfields, where it reopened seats the majoritarian rule had handed to the socialists. It was driven by the entry of new members. Social bills deposited by Catholic and Liberal members rose after 1894, mostly among Catholics, and again after 1900, among Liberals. Enfranchisement thus raised attention to the social question across the country, while proportional representation restored it in the coalfields through the members it elected. Which channel operated was set by the part of the electoral system each reform changed.

Keywords: democratisation, electoral reform, political representation, parliamentary speech, text as data

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